from service. For those who were being retained in service, the payout amount would be merged with their new provident fund account. This was a key feature of the scheme as the payout after four years of service would come to about Rs 10 lakh-plus. An Agniveer who had joined at, say, eighteen years of age, would have a cool Rs 10 lakh in his pocket, much more than any other twenty-one-year-old could ever hope for. This he would be able to use for starting a business or higher education or whatever. The only concern was that he should not fritter away his hard-earned money. Those personnel being retained were to count their service afresh from the bottom of the ladder. This, it was pointed out, would not stand legal scrutiny. After serving for four years in an organization and then continuing in the same organization, how could that person draw a lower salary in the fifth year? In fact, it would result in the anomalous situation of the short-service Agniveer in the fourth year of service getting more pay than the permanently absorbed Agniveer now in the fifth year. This issue was resolved by saying that while he would be counted as being in the first year of service, the last drawn pay would be protected. Why complicate matters? This would then lead to another situation where this person would now have to serve a full fifteen years more to become eligible for pension, rather than only eleven years more. If one of the aims of the Agnipath scheme was to lower the age profile of the Army, then this was a retrograde step, as instead of retiring at thirty-three years of age, the jawan would now retire at thirty-seven years. The policy of giving ante-date seniority is well established and good in law. As and when this aspect rears its head sometime in the future, I am sure that mid-course corrections will be carried out to avoid unnecessary litigation.

The issue of lateral induction, i.e. the side-stepping of service personnel being released into the other Central Armed Police

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